

FYSE 112- Strategies to Succeed in College Courses

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1. **Get the Easy Points.** In each of your classes, determine what the *freebies* are and make sure to get them. In this class, the freebies include:

- Your FYSS 101 grade. The added bonus of staying on top of this is that, if you have a 100 for this at the end of the semester, your final course grade will get rounded up to the nearest point. This can, in some circumstances, make the difference between a B+ and A-, for instance.
- Professional Development.
- Presentation.
- Definitions on the Exam. When you are told what exact questions on a quiz or exam will be, it is easy to earn these points.

Note that the FYSS 101 grade, Professional Development, and Presentation combined, count for 35% of your final grade. The cutoff for a C- is 70%. So by earning the freebies, you reduce the impact of the exams (and this strategy holds true in all of your classes).

2. **Ask for Help.** There are several sources for help in this course.

- Office Hours. These are times that your professors have set aside specifically for you to come in and seek help (see the [course homepage](#)). I am explicitly telling you that I want you to come by my office hours and seek help. Furthermore, I am also available and happy to meet by appointment. Send me an email to schedule an appointment.
- Tutoring. The [Center for Student Learning](#) (located in the Addlestone Library) has tutoring. For this class, Math 207 tutors should be able to assist with the mathematical (non-programming) portions of this class.

3. **Study by Working Problems.** There is considerable peer-reviewed research showing that working problems results in improved performance on quizzes and exams. Do work problems where you are comfortable, but also make sure to work problems where the material is less comfortable.

If you find that you are running out of problems, then create your own. The act of coming up with viable questions that might appear on a quiz or exam is actually a good way to study. Then once you have developed new questions, work through them.

Don't study solely by looking at your notes. This might feel comfortable and productive, but this is not actually helpful in retaining the material (for any class– not just this one).

4. **Work Throughout the Week.** Spend a 2-3 hours every couple of days on a given class, rather than cramming the night before. This has several advantages.

- If you find that you are struggling with a concept, then you have more time to ask for help.
- It is easier to digest the material in smaller increments.
- When you sleep, your brain subconsciously digests the material and assignments. Thus, starting earlier gives your brain more time to absorb material and come up with ideas.

Note that for each course you are taking, you should expect to spend 9-12 hours per week outside of class studying.

5. **Look at Feedback.** When you receive graded work, look at the feedback **immediately** and work to correct any mistakes/misunderstandings. There are three questions to address whenever receiving graded work.

- Why did I get the problem wrong?
 - How do I correctly solve the problem?
 - How could this problem be modified for a future quiz or exam?
6. **Form Study Groups.** One of the best ways to learn the material is to work with others. Trying to explain concepts to others (or even, points at which you are getting lost) is surprisingly helpful for you. And someone else might have an explanation that makes things click for you. Conversely, your explanation of the material might help someone else, and the process of explaining this further reinforces the material for you.
7. **Check Course Communications Regularly.** Make sure you are aware of what is going on in the course and when the deadlines are.
- Spend 30 minutes each day (Monday-Friday) going through your email. Make sure to pay attention to emails from your professors, academic advising, and your home department.
 - Check OAKS each day (Monday-Friday).
 - For this class, check the [course homepage](#) each day (Monday-Friday).